who didn't have to deal with too many dissenting voices. And who, frankly, liked to talk more than listen.

In the next five years leading up to the 2014 elections, Rahul's 'twin vision' shaped his and the Congress party's strategy. 'Inclusiveness' was the new mantra chanted almost routinely while debating economic policy. 'Congress first' became the dominant political philosophy in place of coalition dharma and the idea of a common minimum programme of UPA-I.

In the next two years, Rahul tried to consciously project himself as the *aam aadmi ka sipahi* (common man's soldier)—his heart, we were told, did not lie in the bright lights of the big cities. When he went to Mumbai, he travelled by a local suburban train as if to suggest to the daily commuters that he shared their concerns. When the British foreign secretary David Miliband visited India, Rahul took him for another night stay in a Dalit home in a UP village, and to Amethi to introduce him to the women's self-help groups he had set up there. Critics saw many of Rahul's efforts as tokenism; his image-makers saw it as defining Brand Rahul as a leader of the aam aadmi.

Perhaps the best example of what Rahul was attempting was his intervention in the contentious debate over mining and environment rights in Niyamgiri in Odisha's Kalahandi district. At the heart of the debate was whether the local Dongeria Kondh tribals had rights over their land which had been acquired by the Vedanta group for setting up a $1.7 billion aluminium refinery. The Niyamgiri hills were flush with bauxite deposits but were also part of a rich biodiversity zone. Moreover, the local tribals believed the hill to be sacred and an abode of their deity, Niyam Raja.

Visiting Niyamgiri in March 2008, Rahul grandly announced, *'Kalahandi ka aur Adivasiyon ka Delhi mein ek sipahi hai aur uska naam hai Rahul Gandhi'* (Kalahandi and the tribals have one soldier in Delhi, and his name is Rahul Gandhi). At a press conference in Bhubaneshwar, Rahul underlined his stand. 'I am not against industrialization per se. What I am for is fairness. My personal view is that doing mining there will destroy the environment. It will destroy the water supply of thousands of people. It will destroy their culture. And I am against that personally.'